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EDITORIAL

Introduction: Chinese governance in the era of 'top-level design'[1]

Since Xi Jinping took over at the helm of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP), observers have noted tremendous changes in the structure and operations of the Chinese political system. Reconfigurations of central-local state relations, the shift to a more top-down ('top-level design') and tighter mode of rule, the emergence of Xi as the 'core leader', the enforced anti-corruption campaign, the intensification of ideological propaganda and training, systematic intimidation and censorship, grid systems of community control, and other features, are seen as strongly reminiscent of traditional traits of rule, which were thought to have vanished during the era of reform. At the same time, for many observers, the introduction of ever more comprehensive IT-based social governance and monitoring tools, reforms that target market mechanisms and the legal system, and the expansion of public deliberation and consultation, bespeak the modern and innovative features of Chinese governance.[2] And yet, some very new signals have also emerged, mainly pertaining to policy fields, for instance, the political leadership's new firm commitment to an 'ecological civilization' and green growth, clearer target-based strategies in the international system of science, and new, more assertive activities in the foreign policy realm, such as the Belt and Road Initiative, the manifestations of claims to the South China Sea, and ventures into the Arctic and outer space.

With a particular focus on modes of governance and the design of the policy process, analysts seem to agree, almost unanimously, that what we have seen evolving over the past five years and what is officially promulgated as 'top-level design' by the CCP leadership, is a trend towards *centralization*, or re-centralization. The increased streamlining of policy formulation and monitoring as embodied by the new leading small groups for the 'comprehensive deepening of reforms' at every level of the state hierarchy, with less discretion being allowed for the local adjustment of policies and curtailed open experimentation, various means of firmer top-down cadre management and discipline control, the tightening up of intergovernmental financing, and many other components of the apparently new governance strategy, seem to imply that we can say goodbye, for now, to the era of decentralization, sometimes called quasi-'federalism' by some scholars of Chinese politics.[3] Moreover, debates are taking place on whether this shift entails the old paradigm of 'cyclic changes' of power contraction and enforced top-down steering in Chinese politics[4]—or 'crisis mode' as it has also been called before[5]—or whether, on the contrary, it rather represents an on-going evolutionary process of learning and adjusting.[6]

Complementing these macro analyses, in order to grasp the recurrent and changing features of Chinese governance over time as well as to gauge their effects, new efforts in empirical research and more meticulous analyses are needed. The contributions in this special issue adopt a close-up perspective to examine the particularities of current Chinese governance. Each expert or team of experts working in a relevant field has mapped out a policy field, explored a governance technique and style, or traced cases of institutional reform, in order to examine the continuities and changes observable over the last decade. Overall, this special issue aims to deal with two main questions:

- What, from an overarching viewpoint, is really old or new in the governance patterns since the leadership change in 2013, and what are the implications of these developments? Has governance in China really changed since Xi Jinping came to power? And if it has, what are the appropriate terms for describing what we have observed?
- Even if one can agree that this era is characterized by a more top-down, centralized governance style, in what way does this affect our understanding of the hallmarks of Chinese politics today? Does it imply, for instance, less differentiation (with regard to party–government relations, or the integration of the government, the business and the civic sectors, or the governance of societal groups, for instance) than what was present in previous eras in China? A real alteration in delicate central-local relations? More inclusion or more exclusion of the public in the policy process? A retraction or expansion of addressees included by policies and their outcomes?

Furthermore, each individual article examines the specific features and the actual effects of current governance patterns in China. Questions reflected upon in the various contributions include:

- Can we observe tangible changes in macro concepts and notions constitutive for Chinese politics and modes of governance; for example, nation, state, government/governance, ideology, welfare, justice, etc.?
- How palpable and significant is the new 'top-level design' in certain policy fields? Do we see shifts in content and style?
- Do they actually pervade the whole political system and do they reach down to the bottom, i.e. the local level, where reforms and campaigns are implemented and different actors and interests come together?
- Are changes also tangible in the public reactions to these trends and potentially changing demands for policies or governance modes?
- And, finally, can we already assess whether the newly employed governance features are effective or obstructive with regard to reaching the desired outcomes?

Spotlights on governance in the era of 'top-level design' featured in this special issue

In her comprehensive reflections on the grammar of Chinese governance, Vivienne Shue discusses concepts such as party-state, nation and empire, to make sense of the political entity that modern China has become and the extent to which this is interrelated with China's features of rule. Moreover, for scholars interested in related questions, Shue actually suggests an approach that differs from the usual democracy-autocracy bifurcation in comparative political studies. In her view, empire, particularly in the understanding of the term and its consequences as it has been perceived in recent historical research, can serve as a fruitful concept that can help to further our understanding of Chinese governance. Shue claims that the template of governance under empire has remained a defining element in the basic grammar of current Chinese governance. In her study, she takes us through some of the determining political choices made, the practices adopted, and the social trajectories pursued, which have resulted in this continuity, and looks, in particular, at several techniques of governance associated with empire that are related to scale and strategy, as well as to hierarchy and differentiation. Not least, Shue discusses what this empire-inspired grammar of governance means for our understanding of the governance of China's foreign relations in recent years.

The party leadership's understanding of a regime's collapse, such as the one that ended the Soviet Union, has to be avoided at any cost in China, is a thread that connects Vivienne Shue's reflections of Chinese modern political history with Chen Xuelian's study on what counts in the internal make-up of Chinese governance concepts under 'top-level design'. In her article on the ideological responsibility system used for the management of China's vast body of cadres, Chen traces the contents and characteristics of political streamlining and evaluation over the past four decades. She finds that cadre management in the 'New Era' stands out because of the recent intensification of ideological steering and the stronger focus on loyalty to the central Party leadership. This differs from earlier eras when cadres, by both education and evaluation, were much more encouraged to experiment with (and adjust) policies and politics locally, and when classic political ideology (Marxism-Leninism, Maoism, etc.) was relatively toned down and often gave way to more technocratic guidelines, such as training in local finances or media work/public relations. Finally, Chen considers the ways in which this could influence modes of current Chinese governance.

China's very own path, in comparison to other countries with a Soviet-style regime past, again features as a topic in Neil Munro's article about notions of market justice in China and Russia. Based on a comparative literature review and an analysis of focus group discussions, Munro shows that a combination of subjective economic dissatisfaction, left-leaning political ideology and shock events help explain the demand for both income equality and state welfare provision in both countries. Altogether, he finds that the Chinese, in general, have more nuanced distributive justice attitudes than the Russians, in that they tend to view responsibility for welfare as shared between the state and individuals rather than as the exclusive domain of one or the other.

This, of course, has major implications for welfare governance and the above view indeed seems to be reflected in the design of the Chinese government's contemporary welfare policies. Edward Gu reviews China's health insurance reforms and the government's stated goals of universal coverage, improved benefit design, and smart payment methods. He finds that, although the government in 2011 announced that 95 percent coverage has been achieved for its social health insurance (SHI) schemes, other data sources have revealed less smooth and effective implementation with the result that universal coverage still remains an unfinished task. Gu therefore also comments on the governance features that are still needed in order to ensure the effective working of welfare policies with 'top-level design'.

Finally, Yongdong Shen and Anna L. Ahlers analyze a case of local environmental governance innovation in Hangzhou City. Under the aegis of the central government's new environmental policies since the 2010s, and especially the air pollution action plan of 2014 and the new environmental law of 2015, the status of the local Environmental Protection Bureaus (EPB), in general, has been strengthened. Shen and Ahlers describe a case in which this enabled the EPB in Hangzhou to test an innovative communication mechanism in order to solve a longstanding and stalemated conflict over industrial air pollution between community residents, the polluting enterprises and the local authorities. These trust-building measures eventually led to the successful enforcement of air pollution regulation. Although aware of the limitations of this case study, Shen and Ahlers discuss the impact that new centralized environmental policy-making in China may have on modes of local governance.

Preliminary conclusions

Systematically illuminating, sometimes even questioning the corridor between old and new traits of governance in China, as well as their respective effects, the studies in this special

issue, diverse as they are, all contain a common message: There have been notable changes in the notions and perceptions of many facets of governance in the era of 'top-level design', as proclaimed by the Xi Jinping administration. Pinpointing these and categorizing what we see evolving in summarizing terms and labels, however, is a challenging exercise. Can we speak about *centralized governance* when it is still mainly up to local governments to implement and adjust central policies on the basis of a sometimes astonishing amount of discretionary power and to find solutions to problems that are often not even on the central government's agenda (yet)? Has the political leadership started a new era in the management of its agents, when cadres are actually increasingly being held responsible on the basis of (very) *traditional ideology*? While 'top-level design' seems to have a fertilizing impact on the local prioritization of policies and issues, will it in the long term not stifle open and fruitful local *innovation*? Which type of *authoritarianism* is the most suitable label for Chinese politics, in times of the increased repression of political criticism but increased public input in terms of formulated demands and the ways that new policies are implemented on the ground? Is the verdict 'more authoritarian' in the general political science sense actually still a category that promotes our understanding of contemporary Chinese governance?

While this special issue is not able to present a conclusive characterization of Chinese governance under 'top-level design', it may at least help to trigger further reflections on the above questions. What we can hope for, is to inspire other studies that will boldly discuss the adequacy of old paradigms of Chinese politics and governance at a macro level, as well as accurate studies 'on the ground' on how new notions are playing out and with what sort of long-term implications, bridging detailed empirics with the bigger picture.

Notes

1. The guest editor and the authors would like to extend their warm thanks to the discussants during the Conference of the German Association for Social Science Research on China (ASC) in Cologne, 2017, as well as to all colleagues who were kindly willing to review the articles for this special issue - mostly at rather short notice during the stressful later phase of the preparations for this publication. We are also grateful to Anna Mackay who, also at short notice and excellently as always, proofread some of the texts assembled here. Last but not least, all remaining errors are our own.
2. Cf., for example, Nathan, "Authoritarian Resilience"; Yang, Remaking the Chinese Leviathan; Hu, Tang, Yang, and Yan, *The Modernization of China's State Governance*. For macro accounts on China's current form of authoritarianism, see Minzner, *End of an Era*; Shambaugh, *China's Future*.
3. See, most prominently, Jin, Qian, and Weingast, "Regional Decentralization and Fiscal Incentives"; Montinola, Qian, and Weingast, "Federalism, Chinese Style."
4. See, for example, Chung, *Centrifugal Empire*.
5. See, for example, Heilmann, *China's Political System*; *Red Swan*.
6. See, for example, Shue and Thornton, *To Govern China*.

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